DEVORA RESEARCH & GUIDES

The Async-First Handbook

How to structure decisions, docs, and standups for a team that isn't all online at once.

Devora

Sample document created for the Devora demo website.

What async-first actually means

Async-first does not mean never talking. It means that the default way work moves forward is through written, durable messages that anyone can read when they are ready, and that meetings are a deliberate exception rather than the habit.

The payoff is practical. Teams spread across time zones stop waiting a full day for answers, focused work stops being interrupted, and decisions leave a written trail that new teammates can learn from.

Principles

- **Write it down.** If it matters, it lives in a doc or ticket, not in someone's memory.
- **Default to open.** Discussion happens in shared channels, not private messages.
- **Make decisions explicit.** Every thread ends with who decided what, and by when.
- **Respect response windows.** Agree what 'urgent' means so everything else can wait.

Decisions that do not need a meeting

Use a short decision doc: the problem, the options considered, the recommendation, and a deadline for objections. Silence by the deadline counts as agreement. This simple pattern replaces a large share of status and alignment meetings.

Section	What to write
Context	Two or three sentences on why this decision is needed now
Options	Two to four real alternatives, with trade-offs
Recommendation	What you propose and why
Deadline	The date after which the proposal is considered accepted

Standups without the standing

A written standup takes two minutes to write and a minute to read. Ask each person to post three lines at the start of their day: what I finished, what I am doing next, and where I am blocked. Blockers are the only part that needs a reply.

A template that works

- **Done:** shipped the checkout error states
- **Next:** start the receipts email template
- **Blocked:** need API keys for the email provider (@ops)

Docs that people actually read

Keep documents short, titled by outcome ('How we release on Fridays'), and owned by a named person. Put the answer in the first paragraph and the background below it. Review owned docs every quarter and archive the ones nobody opens.

When a meeting is the right tool

Some things are genuinely better live: sensitive feedback, creative brainstorming, resolving a disagreement that has bounced around in writing for more than a day, and building trust with new teammates. Keep these, and make each one have an agenda and a written summary.

Use async for	Use a meeting for
Status updates	Hard conversations
Decisions with clear options	Early, ambiguous brainstorming
Reviews and feedback on work	Resolving long-running disagreements
Announcements	Onboarding and team bonding

Handoffs across time zones

End each day with a short handoff note: current state, next step, and anything the next person might trip over. Include links, not descriptions. A good note lets someone pick up the work cold without a conversation.

Getting started in one week

Day	Action
Monday	Agree response windows and what counts as urgent
Tuesday	Move one recurring status meeting to a written update
Wednesday	Introduce the decision-doc template
Thursday	Start written standups
Friday	Review what felt slower and what felt calmer

This is a sample guide produced for the Devora demo site. Replace it with your own published research.